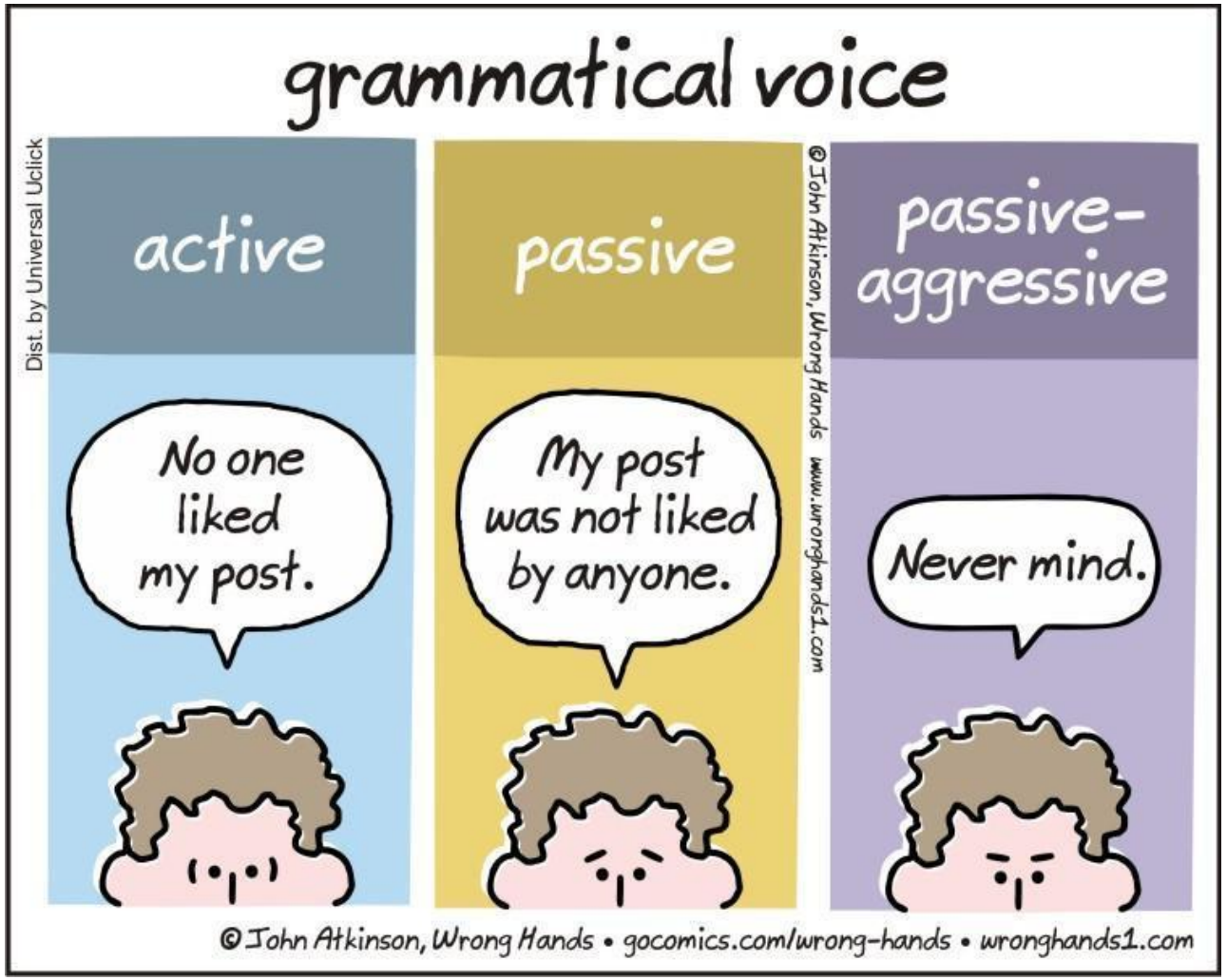
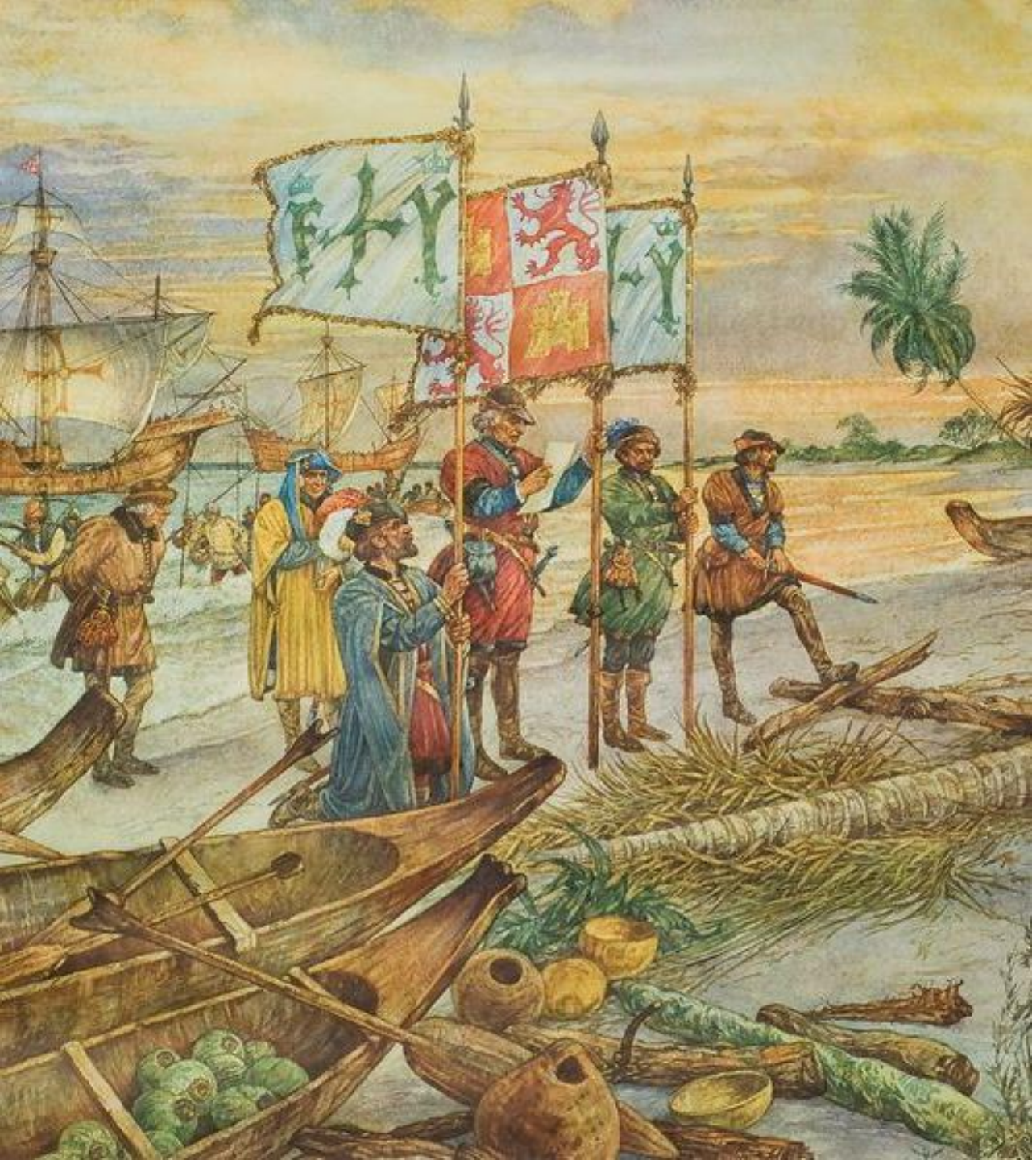
GRAMMAR & BASICA

The Passive





Consider this text:

Christopher Columbus was a navigator and a colonizer. He was born in Italy in 1451. In 1492 Columbus discovered America. He thought he had discovered Asia!

This text is about Columbus.

The focus is on what he did.

Columbus is the subject and the agent.

"Columbus discovered America" is an active sentence.

NOW CONSIDER THIS TEXT

The United States of America is a republic, which consists of 50 states. The capital is Washington. In 1492 America was discovered by Christopher Columbus.

This text is about the USA. The focus is on <u>what happened</u> to it.

America is the subject, but Columbus is still the <u>agent</u>

"America was discovered by Columbus" is a <u>passive</u> sentence.

THE PASSIVE

1. Columbus *discovered* America.

2. America *was discovered* by Columbus.

- What has changed?

ACTIVE

Columbus	discovered	America
subject	verb	object

PASSIVE

America	was discovered	by Columbus
subject	verb	adverbial (agent)

WHAT HAS CHANGED?

The **object** of sentence one (America) has become the **subject**.

Columbus discovered America.

America was discovered by Columbus.

WHAT ELSE HAS CHANGED?

1. Columbus ***discovered*** America.

2. America ***was discovered*** by Columbus.

WHAT ELSE HAS CHANGED?

1. Columbus ***discovered*** America
   - Past simple

1. America ***was discovered*** by Columbus
   - form of ‘to be’ (in the same tense) + past participle

HOW TO MAKE AN ACTIVE SENTENCE PASSIVE

1. Make the **object** of the active sentence the subject of the passive sentence
2. Use a form of **(to) be** in the same tense and use the **past participle** (of the verb in the active sentence)
3. If relevant, the subject of the active sentence can be put at the end in an **adverbial** (by-phrase)

HOW TO MAKE AN ACTIVE SENTENCE PASSIVE

John	opens	the door
subject	verb	object

The door	is opened	(by John)
subject	verb	object

THE PASSIVE

We saw an example of the past simple tense

(*America was discovered by Columbus*)

and

of the present simple tense

(*the door is opened*)

- The passive can be used in <u>nearly all of the tenses</u>

TENSES AND THE PASSIVE

Form	Active	Passive
Present simple	They clean the house	The house is cleaned (by them)
Present continuous	They are cleaning the house	The is being cleaned (by them)
Present perfect	They have cleaned the house	The house has been cleaned (by them)
Past simple	They cleaned the house	The house was cleaned (by them)
Past continuous	They were cleaning the house	The house was being cleaned (by them)
Past perfect	They had cleaned the house	The house had been cleaned (by them)
Future	They will* clean the house	The house will be cleaned
* Same for all modal verbs		

Savage Chickens
by Doug Savage
AN ERROR HAS OCCURRED. I'M SAYING THIS IN THE PASSIVE VOICE TO AVOID TAKING ANY PERSONAL RESPONSIBILITY.
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VERBS THAT TAKE TWO OBJECTS

Verb	Active	Passive
give	The nurse **gives** the patient a sleeping pill.	A sleeping pill **is given** to the patient.
		The patient **is given** a sleeping pill.
allow, ask, feed, send		
	The man **fed** the horse a bale of hay.	A bale of hay **was fed** to the horse.
		The horse **was fed** a bale of hay.

EXCEPTIONS (I)

Verb	Active	Passive
Verbs without object		
happen	Something **happened**	x
stay	We **stayed** at home	
Some state verbs		
lack	The player **lacks** talent	x
have	We **have** three dogs	x

EXCEPTIONS (II)

Verb	Active	Passive
Verbs that are <u>action</u> and <u>state</u> verbs. Only passive when they are **action** verbs (cost, fit, measure, weigh)		
As a state verb		
weigh	The person **weighed** 80 kilos	-
As an action verb		
weigh	The woman **weighed** the apples on the scale	The apples **were weighed** on the scale (by the woman)

Passive

usage

WHEN TO USE? - I

1. When we focus on the person/thing undergoing the action (even though the agent is mentioned)
   - *America* ***was dicovered*** *by Columbus.*

2. You find this in formal, academic writing, textbooks, news reports.

WHEN TO USE? - II

3. When we <u>don't know who the agent is</u> (and cannot possibly know).
   - My bike has been stolen.
   - The house was broken into.

WHEN TO USE? - III

4. It's irrelevant to mention the agent.

4a. Because it's obvious:

- Yesterday the thief ***was arrested.***
- This is the hospital where she ***was treated.***

4b. Because the emphasis is on the process, not the ones doing it:

- The water ***is heated*** in a test tube.

WHEN TO USE? - IV

5. When the agent is everyone/ (a group of) people in general.
    - *Books **can be borrowed** at a library.*
    - *English and French **are spoken** in Canada.*

WHEN TO USE? - V

6. When you choose not to mention the agent to avoid blaming anyone.
   - *Mistakes **were made.***
   - *I'm afraid the wrong products **were sent** to us.*

TRANSLATING

Watch out when translating Dutch “er”:

- **Er** zijn veel mensen ontslagen.
- *~~There have been many people fired.~~
- Many people have been fired.

Active voice
Passive voice